Wikipedia The Free Encyclopedia

Search Wikipedia | Search

Donate Create account Log in

Infix

40 languages

Article Talk | Read Edit View history Tools

From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

This article is about infixes in natural languages. For the mathematical notation, see Infix notation.

This article includes a list of general references, but **it lacks sufficient corresponding inline citations**. Please help to improve this article by introducing more precise citations. *(January 2024) (Learn how and when to remove this message)*

An **infix** is an affix inserted inside a word stem (an existing word or the core of a family of words). It contrasts with *adfix,* a rare term for an affix attached to the outside of a stem, such as a prefix or suffix.[note 1]

When marking text for interlinear glossing, most affixes are separated with a hyphen, but infixes are separated with ⟨angle brackets⟩.

Affixes

Prefix · Suffix · Circumfix · Duplifix · **Infix** · Libfix · Interfix · Transfix · Simulfix · Suprafix · Disfix

See also:

Null morpheme

v · t · e

English [edit]

English has almost no true infixes and those it does have are marginal. Most are heard in colloquial speech;[1] although there are other examples, such as in technical terminology, these examples are often more accurately described as tmesis.[2]

Colloquialisms [edit]

None of the following are recognized in standard English.

- The infix ⟨-iz-⟩ or ⟨-izn-⟩ is characteristic of hip-hop slang, for example *h-**iz**-ouse* for *house* and *sh-**izn**-it* for *shit.*
- The ⟨-ma-⟩ infix (or "Homeric infix," after Homer Simpson),[3] gives a word an ironic pseudo-sophistication, as in *sophisti-**ma**-cated (sophisticated), saxo-**ma**-phone,* (saxophone) and *edu-**ma**-cation.* (education) This exists as a slang phenomenon.
- Infixes also occur in some language games.
- The use of 'expletive infixes' such as *-fucking-* and *-bloody-*, which are words rather than affixes, is known as tmesis.

Indo-European nasal infix [edit]

Main article: Nasal infix

The present tense of some Proto-Indo-European verbs, in the case of a certain number of roots, adds a nasal infix (*m*, *n*) to the basic root. The stems of the other tenses have the root without the infix, and thus these verbs are called *nasal-presents*. This phenomenon is inherited, and preserved to varying degrees, by some early daughter languages such as Sanskrit, Ancient Greek, Latin language, etc.[4]

- Sanskrit exhibits the greatest transparency of this feature amongst the Indo-European languages, with the phenomenon manifesting in three of the ten traditional verb classes, where the infix is higher-grade and accent-bearing in the strong forms, and reduced-grade in the weak forms.[5][6] For example, √*yuj*-, 'join' has *yu·ná·k·ti* 's/he joins' ↔ *yu·ñj·ánti*, 'they join'.[7]
- Latin present *vi**n**cō* "I win" (cf. perfect passive participle *victus* "conquered")[8]
- Ancient Greek *la**m**bánō* (also with *-an-* suffix) "I take" (cf. aorist *élăbon* "I took")[9]

Spanish [edit]

In Nicaraguan, Costa Rican, and Honduran Spanish, the Spanish diminutive affix becomes an infix ⟨it⟩ in names: *Óscar* [ˈoskar] → *Osquítar* [osˈkitar] (cf. standard *Oscarito*); *Edgar* → *Edguítar*; *Victor* → *Victítor*. This diminutive infix can also be found for the word *azúcar*, due to its unusual form as a paroxytone word with a final /r/, giving *azuquítar*.[10]

Portuguese [edit]

In Portuguese, some pronominal verbal forms have infixes, like *dir-lhe-ei* "(I) will tell him" where *lhe* is the "him" pronoun. Most seen on conditional and futures tenses of the indicative mode, but not very common.

Arabic [edit]

Arabic uses a common infix, ⟨t⟩ ت for Form VIII verbs, usually a reflexive of Form I. It is placed after the first consonant of the root; an epenthetic *i-* prefix is also added, since words cannot begin with a consonant cluster. An example is اجتهد *ijtahada* "he worked hard", from جهد *jahada* "he strove". (The words *ijtihad* and *jihad* are nouns derived from these two verbs.)

Austronesian and Austroasiatic languages [edit]

Infixes are common in some Austronesian and Austroasiatic languages, but not in others. For example, in Tagalog, a grammatical form similar to the active voice is formed by adding the infix ⟨um⟩ near the beginning of a verb. The most common infix is ⟨in⟩ which marks the perfect aspect, as in 'giniba', meaning 'ruined' (from '*giba*', an adjective meaning 'worn-out'); '*binato*', meaning 'stoned' (from '*bato*', 'stone'); and '*ginamit*', meaning 'used'[*vague*]. Tagalog has borrowed the English word *graduate* as a verb; to say "I graduated" a speaker uses the derived form *gr**um**aduate*.

Khmer, an Austroasiatic language, has seven different infixes. They include the nominalizing infix ⟨b⟩, which derives ***lb**ɨən* 'speed' from *lɨən* 'fast' and ***lb**ɑɑng* ' trial' from *lɔɔng* 'to test, to haunt', or the agentive ⟨m⟩ deriving ***cm**am* 'watchman' from *cam* 'to watch'. These elements are no longer productive, and occur crystallized in words inherited from Old Khmer.

In Malay and Indonesian, there are three infixes (*sisipan*), ⟨el⟩, ⟨em⟩, and ⟨er⟩. All infixes are no longer productive and cannot be used to derive new words. Examples include:

- The word 'gembung' (variant of 'kembung') means "bloated", while 'g**el**embung' means "bubble"'.
- The word 'cerlang' means "luminous", while 'c**em**erlang' means "brilliant"'.
- The word 'gigi' means "tooth", while 'g**er**igi' means "serration"'.

Seri [edit]

In Seri, some verbs form the plural stem with infixation of ⟨tóo⟩ after the first vowel of the root; compare the singular stem *ic* 'plant (verb)' with the plural stem *itóoc*. Examples: *itíc* 'did s/he plant it?' and *iti**tóo**c* 'did they sow it?'.

Similar processes [edit]

Tmesis, the use of a lexical word rather than an affix, is sometimes considered a type of infixation. These are the so-called "expletive infixes", as in *abso-bloody-lutely*. Since these are not affixes[*citation needed*], they are commonly disqualified from being considered infixes.

Sequences of adfixes (prefixes or suffixes) do not result in infixes: an infix must be internal to a word stem. Thus, the word *originally,* formed by adding the suffix *-ly* to *original,* does not turn the suffix *-al* into an infix. There is simply a sequence of two suffixes, *origin-al-ly.* In order for *-al-* to be considered an infix, it would have to have been inserted in the non-existent word **originly.* The "infixes" in the tradition of Bantu linguistics are often sequences of prefixes of this type, though there may be debate over specific cases.

The Semitic languages have a form of *ablaut* (changing the vowels within words, as in English *sing, sang, sung, song)* that is sometimes called infixation, as the vowels are placed between the consonants of the root. However, this interdigitation of a discontinuous root with a discontinuous affix is more often called *transfixation*.

An *interfix* joins a compound word, as in *speed-o-meter*.

Glossing [edit]

When glossing, it is conventional to set off infixes with ⟨angle brackets⟩, rather than the hyphens used to set off prefixes and suffixes:

sh⟨izn⟩it, saxo⟨ma⟩phone, pi⟨pe⟩coline

Compare:

origin-al-ly

which contains the suffix *-ly* added to the word *original,* which is itself formed by adding the suffix *-al* to the root *origin.*

See also [edit]

- Circumfix
- Clitic
- Expletive infixation
- Tree traversal

For a list of words relating to infixes, see the ***Infixes by language*** category of words in Wiktionary, the free dictionary.

Notes [edit]

1. ^ In mathematics, the terms prefix ("Polish Notation") and postfix are used.

References [edit]

1. ^ Luu, Chi (2015-04-28). "Fanf-kingtastic and Edumacational: The Case of English Infixation". *JSTOR Daily*. Retrieved 2023-02-17.
2. ^ McMillan, James B. (1980). "Infixing and Interposing in English". *American Speech*. **55** (3): 163–183. doi:10.2307/455082. ISSN 0003-1283. JSTOR 455082.
3. ^ Yu 2004
4. ^ Fortson 2010, §5.25
5. ^ Szemerényi 1996, §9.4.1.3
6. ^ Burrow 2001, p. 289
7. ^ Burrow 2001, §7.8
8. ^ vinco. Charlton T. Lewis and Charles Short. *A Latin Dictionary* on Perseus Project.
9. ^ λαμβάνω. Liddell, Henry George; Scott, Robert; *A Greek–English Lexicon* at the Perseus Project
10. ^ Akmajian, Adrian; Farmer, Ann K.; Bickmore, Lee; Demers, Richard A.; Harnish, Robert M. (2017). *Linguistics : An Introduction to Language and Communication* (7th ed.). Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press. ISBN 9780262533263.

Bibliography [edit]

- Fortson, Benjamin W (2010). *Indo-European Language and Culture*. Wiley-Blackwell. ISBN 978-1-4051-8895-1.
- Szemerényi, Oswald JL (1996). *Introduction to Indo-European Linguistics*. Great Britain: Clarendon Oxford. ISBN 0-19-824015-5.
- Burrow, T (2001). *The Sanskrit Language*. Motilal Banarsidass. ISBN 81-208-1767-2.
- Yu, Alan C. L. (2004). "Reduplication In English Homeric Infixation". *Proceedings of the North East Linguistic Society*. University of Massachusetts.

Further reading [edit]

- *Alexis Amid Neme and Eric Laporte (2013), Pattern-and-root inflectional morphology: the Arabic broken plural* |year=
- *Alexis Amid Neme and Eric Laporte (2015), Do computer scientists deeply understand Arabic morphology? - هل يفهم المهندسون الحاسوبيّون علم الصرف فهماً عميقاً؟*, available also in Arabic, Indonesian, French

Authority control databases: National | Czech Republic · Israel

Category: Infixes

This page was last edited on 11 June 2025, at 16:55 (UTC).

Text is available under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 License; additional terms may apply. By using this site, you agree to the Terms of Use and Privacy Policy. Wikipedia® is a registered trademark of the Wikimedia Foundation, Inc., a non-profit organization.

Privacy policy About Wikipedia Disclaimers Contact Wikipedia Code of Conduct Developers Statistics Cookie statement Mobile view